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Speed-Interviewing for Classroom Group Formation: How a Clever Twist on the Classic "Speed-Dating" Tradition Enhances Small Group Coursework

Lisa W. Sublett[1], Amanda M. Johnston[1], Christine A. P. Walther[1], Christal Seahorn[1], Georgina L. Moreno[1], and Latoya Brownlee[1]

Abstract

Introduction: Students in higher education courses need to practice vital groupwork skills that are increasingly relevant in today's collaborative workplace, which often occurs through small group coursework.

Statement of the Problem: The process of forming small groups with students who are committed to the topic and goals is frequently problematic.

Literature Review: We review the literature on the advantages and disadvantages of common group formation strategies, such as self-assembly and professor assignment.

Teaching Implications: We discuss the use of a unique method of forming small groups in a university setting through a fun, interactive activity based on the classic "speed-dating" exercise.

Conclusion: We recommend that educators consider the use of a speed-interviewing group formation strategy to allow groups to form based on similar topic interests and work styles.

Keywords

pedagogical activity, speed-interviewing, student interaction, group formation, group commitment, group cohesion, group work, workgroups

Since the late 20th century, scholars have advocated for collaboration as a pedagogical tool (e.g., Bruffee, 1984; Sharan & Sharan, 1976; Slavin, 1991), and the ability "to collaborate successfully on small group classroom assignments [and] … complex group projects" is an American Psychological Association (APA) learning goal for psychology students in higher education (APA, 2013, p. 35). There is general agreement about the potential of group projects to help students acquire skills, form peer connections, and demonstrate autonomous active learning (Hansen & Hansen, 2007; Rundle, 2014), but forming those groups often come with challenges (Seethamraju & Borman, 2009). Customary classroom group formation strategies include self-assembly and professor assignment (Chapman et al., 2006). While each of these strategies has its own advantages, they also have significant shortcomings (Bacon et al., 2001; Chapman et al., 2006; Curseu et al., 2010). In this article, we review the literature on **the** advantages and disadvantages of these common group formation strategies, then, we share a unique group formation strategy that aims to leverage the benefits and minimize the deficiencies of customary approaches through an interactive speed-interviewing activity. Our usage of speed interviewing to form groups answers a call from Bailey et al. (2015) for increased instructor guidance to improve psychology majors' perceptions and experience with collaborative groupwork.

Group Formation

Past research on workgroups finds that the stronger a person's self-categorization is to the group, the more likely they will act in the interest of the group (Turner et al., 1987). Self-Categorization theory (Turner et al., 1987) explores identity in terms of self and group. As group identity becomes more significant to their self-identity, group members report higher group identification and morale-building communication (Michinov et al., 2004) and more effective group performance (Ellemers & Rink, 2005). People are likely to socially categorize themselves and form groups based on similarity. The similarity-attraction bias describes how humans are drawn to people who look, act, and believe similarly to themselves (Byrne, 1971). These similarities can be *surface-level* dimensions (e.g., race, gender) or *deep-level* dimensions (e.g., beliefs, goals). Groups based on surface-level attributes often

[1] University of Houston – Clear Lake, Houston, TX, USA

Corresponding Author:
Lisa W. Sublett, Department of Clinical, Health and Applied Sciences, University of Houston – Clear Lake, 2700 Bay Area Blvd, Houston, TX 77058, USA.
Email: sublett@uhcl.edu

fail, engage in groupthink, and lead to less diverse ideas (Phillips et al., 2006), while groups with deep-level similarity are higher performing and more cohesive (Jackson et al., 2017).

In a higher education classroom, group formation often occurs on a tight schedule and, typically, with limited familiarity among classmates. Thus, it is often difficult to form groups based on deep-level similarity, and "professors and students often report dissatisfaction" with groupwork (Swaim & Henley, 2017, p. 119). In the following sections, we discuss two common group formation strategies in the classroom: self-assembly and professor assignment. We then describe how the novel speed-interviewing (i.e., "speed-dating") activity can harness the advantages of both group formation strategies in an efficient way that emphasizes deep-level similarity based on topic congruence.

Self-Assembly

In self-assembled groups, professors allow students to self-select their group members. This strategy provides agency, preferred choices, and increased in-group identity (Bacon et al., 2001; Chapman et al., 2006; Curseu et al., 2010; Wax et al., 2017). Furthermore, self-assembled groups can have a lesser incidence of social loafing due to voluntary commitment, group solidarity, and group cohesion (Aggarwal & O'Brien, 2008; Mahenthiran & Rouse, 2000; Strong & Anderson, 1990). Drawing from the self-categorization theory, the stronger a person's self-categorization is as a member of a group, the more likely they will act in the interest of the group (Turner et al., 1987). When classmates self-assemble through previously developed friendships, they have already developed higher levels of interaction, which is crucial for effective knowledge sharing among group members (Jans et al., 2015). Self-assembled groups also have disadvantages. In a higher education setting, classmates do not typically have close friendships as they would in grade school, so self-assembled groups often form based on surface-level dimensions such as "proximity" (Wax et al., 2017, p. 701). This increases the likelihood of biases when students choose groups on surface-level similarity (e.g., gender) rather than deep-level similarity (e.g., congruent interests). Past research finds surface-level homophily (e.g., ethnicity, age, proximity) can lead to in-group homogeneity-related issues with gender and ethno-racial biases (Jackson et al., 2017).

Professor Assignment

Another common method of group formation occurs through professor assignment when professors randomly assign students to groups (Johnson et al., 1994; Swaim & Henley, 2017). Students prefer professor-assigned groups when it removes social pressure/desirability and helps shy or socially anxious students, who may be left out in self-assembled formation (Chapman et al., 2006; Hübscher, 2010). Professor assignment also mimics the real world, as workgroups are assigned by a supervisor (Blowers, 2003). Thus, professor-assigned groups are likely to provide pedagogical opportunities that expand students' competencies for working in groups in the workplace. There are also disadvantages of assigned workgroups. Instructors and students report dissatisfaction due to a lack of agency and preferred choices (Hansen, 2006; Lindholm et al., 2005; Miles & Klein, 1998). Additionally, professor-assigned options may decrease independence and social cohesion during the early stages of group formation (Hansen & Hansen, 2007).

Speed-Interviewing Activity

Developed in the 1990s as a matchmaking strategy for Jewish singles, "speed-dating" has only recently been adapted as a pedagogical tool (Muurlink & Matas, 2011). The brief time allowed for one-on-one interactions promotes purposeful concentration, reduces social loafing, and invites a high level of engagement within a low-risk activity. Similar approaches, such as "speed-interviewing," "rapid-interviewing," or "speedstorming" (Joyce et al., 2010), are becoming increasingly common in applied settings (Lui, 2020). This speed-interviewing style has demonstrated benefits for class discussions (Maidment & Crisp, 2007; Murphy, 2005). Rapid interviewing to form groups can capitalize on the benefits of classic workgroup formation strategies offered in previous studies (e.g., Chapman et al., 2006; Swaim & Henley, 2017; Wax et al., 2017).

This novel activity is a time-efficient method that emphasizes purposeful group selection based on topic congruence, allows for the individual agency by encouraging student feedback, removes common selection biases that are detrimental to workgroup heterogeneity, and mirrors the real world with assignment by a superior. Organizing a speed-interviewing activity provides a controlled technique for students to discuss topic interests in class. This activity promotes a high level of student engagement and communication and fast tracks in-group social categorization (Turner et al., 1987). A strict time limit invites an efficient use of knowledge sharing among peers. Students evoke agency by providing their individual preferences and choices based on the speed-interviewing activity, and the professor designs groups based on these preferences and shared topic interests. Because the activity prioritizes cohesion through deep-level dimensions instead of commonly used biases, it allows for early in-group identity and commitment to the project topic.

Materials

All "speed-dating" activity materials can be found on figshare.com: https://doi.org/10.6084/m9.figshare.20402349.v2. This link provides access to a document titled "Materials and Instructions for the 'Speed-Dating' Activity for Forming Small Groups," which includes specific instructions for the instructor to implement the activity, suggestions for modifying the activity for online delivery, and all activity materials (Sublett et al., 2022).

Activity Format and Structure

During the first half of the semester, students in undergraduate and graduate Psychology courses and undergraduate Writing

Table 1. Student Feedback: "What Were the Benefits of the 'Speed-Dating' Exercise?".

Theme	Example	*n*	%
1. Discussion of topics and interests	"seeing who shares interests"	122	53%
2. Greater interactions with classmates	"we were able to talk to everyone"	100	43%
3. Formed functioning groups	"my group also worked together really well"	34	15%
4. Forced to be more direct with time constraints	"I got to hear everyone's topic quickly and briefly"	22	10%
5. Freedom to choose/autonomy	"allows us to have freedom and have a say in choosing someone"	8	3%
6. Increased cohesion with the entire class	"I feel connected to the class because I got to meet everyone"	5	2%

Note. Count indicates the number of times a theme was mentioned across all student feedback. Responses could incorporate more than one theme. The percentage was calculated out of $N = 231$.

courses participated in the speed-interviewing activity to form groups for a required course project. Classes ranged from 15 to 40 students, and each group had 3–5 students. Courses in Psychology completed a research project where a group of students collaborated to select a topic, conduct a literature review, design a research study to test a hypothesis, and prepare a final paper and/or presentation. The Writing course projects followed the same design through the literature review and presented their findings to the class without testing hypotheses. Each project transpired over several weeks and was worth 15–25% of the final course grade.

Professors explained to students that the activity would be a variation of the classic "speed-dating" activity often portrayed in movies and television where they will meet with each of their classmates for a brief period. Students were instructed to prepare their own topic proposals and interests to discuss during these interviews. Professors arranged the physical space for the speed-interviewing activity. In cases where professors wanted an open layout, professors had to strategically create a space unencumbered by the presence of physical obstacles like tables and chairs. The class was either moved to an open area on campus or they moved tables/chairs to the walls to allow for space in the center of the room. When classes were in computer labs, professors instructed students to use space on the perimeter of the room or at the front so the computers would create only minimal constraints.

Students wore nametags and were provided a list of their classmates' names. During each one-on-one conversation, students discussed their topic interests with each other for one minute. The professor served as the timekeeper and announced when it was time to switch partners after the one-minute timer concluded for each interview. During or immediately following each conversation, students wrote brief notes about each student they interviewed on the provided preference sheet. The preference sheet included the names of all students, a column for notes, and a column for indicating the immediate preference of each person as a group project member (i.e., Yes/No/Maybe). During the interviews, the students were encouraged to write notes and their initial reactions to each person, paying special attention to the topic and project ideas. This process concluded once every student had interviewed every other student in the class. Instructors can access these preference sheets in the document titled "Materials and Instructions for the 'Speed-Dating' Activity for Forming Small Groups" (Sublett et al., 2022).

After completing all interviews, students returned to their seats and independently reviewed their notes to complete the second page of the rating sheet that provided space for students to indicate their four most-desired selections and up to four least-desired selections with rationale. Instructors reminded students they should emphasize project ideas and topics. The professor then determined the groups by matching students based on their submitted four most-desired preferences. Typically, 1–2 students in each class did not make anyone's most-desired candidate list. In these instances, instructors reviewed least-desired lists and the first page's initial reactions columns (i.e., Yes/No/Maybe) to match these students to groups. The total duration of the activity depended on the total number of students in the class and ranged from 45 min to 1.5 h.

Student Feedback

During the final week of the semester, after the course project was submitted or close to being submitted, students provided feedback on the "speed-dating" activity. The average length of time between the "speed-dating" activity and providing feedback was approximately 6 weeks, with a range of 4–8 weeks. Students were told providing feedback was anonymous and optional.

Compared to other group formation methods, which were usually assignment to groups by a professor or use of self-selection methods to form groups, students reported that speed-interviewing resulted in more cohesive groups because it focused on interests/topics, provided agency/autonomy, gave students a chance to meet peers, was based on personality/work style fit, was more entertaining and fun, and was more efficient. Students also expressed an interest in participating in the speed-interviewing process in the future or recommending the activity to other professors. Students reported numerous benefits to participating in the "speed-dating" activity. The most common stated benefit was the ability to discuss topics and interests with classmates. Students also stated that they experienced greater interactions with classmates, formed functioning groups, were forced to be direct with time constraints, had agency/autonomy, and experienced increased class cohesion (Tables 1 and 2).

Students were pointedly asked about challenges and to describe ways they would suggest improving the "speed-dating" activity. Many students reported there were no ways to improve, and other students provided valuable suggestions for

Table 2. Student Feedback: "How Does the 'Speed-Dating' Activity Compare to Previous Experiences in Groups?."

Theme	Example	*n*	%
Better		181	78%
1. Focused on interests/topics	"helps each other know what areas we like to study"	29	13%
2. Provided the freedom to choose/autonomy	"better because of choice"	26	11%
3. Gives chance to talk to and get to know all peers	"It was much better to get to meet and talk to people."	20	9%
4. Can choose members based on personality/work style fit	"better because actually got to see the effort and preparation people put into their topic"	17	7%
5. Better but did not specify why	"this process was better"	16	7%
6. More entertaining/fun/enjoyable	"I think it is innovative and it makes it more fun"	13	6%
7. More efficient/faster	"I believe it was more efficient."	8	3%
8. Provided structure; not just a free for all	"there was no awkwardness on what to do"	7	3%
Same	"about the same"	13	6%
Worse		11	5%
1. Worse but did not specify why	"I ended up with a worse group than I've ever had"	11	5%
2. Hectic/too fast	"more chaotic"	6	3%
3. Stressful or anxiety-provoking	"stressful"	5	2%
4. Slow process to choose groups	"this process was longer"	3	1%

Note. Count indicates the number of times a theme was mentioned across all student feedback. Responses could incorporate more than one theme. The percentage was calculated out of $N = 231$.

improvement. Many students felt it was too fast. Other challenges were difficulty with communicating and hearing, initiating conversations, finding classmates, moving around the room, and remembering everyone's topic and name. The most common suggestion was providing more time for each interview. Other suggestions included having a more organized physical space, encouraging students to come more prepared for the activity, and creating a more accessible environment for hearing.

Instructor experiences with the activity mirrored the student experiences. In general, we observed a high level of student engagement during the activity and only minor challenges. Immediately following the activity, multiple students expressed their enjoyment, positivity, and gratitude for the activity. Additionally, on the anonymous course evaluations administered at the end of the semester, the speed-interviewing activity was repeatedly mentioned as an aspect of the course that worked well. Student recognition of the novelty and utility of the activity via formal and informal feedback suggests that its use would be advantageous in future courses.

Educational Implications

The speed-interviewing activity allowed students to voice their opinions with the preference sheet, increasing a sense of agency and responsibility for the group's success. By having professors organize final groups, the activity mimics the workplace in which a supervisor assigns workgroups. Another clear strength of the activity was the positive impact on the broader classroom environment. Students acknowledged the opportunity to connect with other peers in the class as a benefit, and a subset of students indicated that the interaction allowed them to further develop their ideas. An environment that encourages interactions among all members reduces prejudice and increases positive attitudes (Aronson & Yates, 1983). Interaction with peers during the speed-interviewing activity, particularly those with whom students may not regularly interact, created an environment early in the semester that likely resulted in more classroom inclusivity. Because of this benefit to the overall classroom environment, we suggest implementing this activity at the beginning of the semester.

This activity has pedagogical implications for higher education classes with small group coursework. The speed-interviewing activity provides an efficient, interactive way to form groups with members who are committed to the topic. One-on-one interviews with classmates emphasize the importance of developing deep-level similarity based on topic congruence. The activity is particularly suitable for projects where topic congruence is a priority.

The speed-interviewing activity takes a significant amount of time, ranging from 45 min to 2 h, depending on the class size. Thus, we suggest this activity be used for small classes (i.e., fewer than 40 students). The activity's time commitment would also be warranted for projects that require extended dedication across the semester or encompass a vital component of the course.

According to the student feedback, many students reported difficulty with the one-minute time limit. We would recommend increasing the time limit in certain circumstances, such as for classes with students with disabilities (e.g., ADHD, Autism Spectrum Disorder, mobility challenges) who require accommodation. Allowing for more time for interviews and professor-determined rotation procedures can address some of these accessibility concerns. Although the time limit format may initially be daunting for students, we believe the time limit teaches students the importance of being succinct, yet sophisticated, in their oral presentations.

Students reported several benefits (e.g., cohesive groups, peer interaction, increased agency). The activity clearly

benefited the group projects in terms of idea development and group cohesiveness, but we are uncertain whether the activity benefited the quality of the work. Future research could examine the relationship between participation in the speed-interviewing activity and final project grades.

Conclusion

Learning to collaborate in group settings is a critical skill for students in higher education. Inventive group formation activities, such as speed interviewing, can combine the strengths of traditional approaches to group formation and minimize the weaknesses of these traditional strategies. Both instructor observation and student feedback support the use of speed interviewing as an alternative to more traditional methods of group formation for course projects. In addition, students are given unique opportunities in the "speed-dating" activity to develop important skills, such as early idea development and communication of ideas, which are lacking in other group formation options.

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ORCID iD

Lisa W. Sublett https://orcid.org/0000-0002-8025-6633

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